Sharjah Tourism Innovation Hackathon 2026

HACKATHON GUIDELINES

1. Project Scope

Projects must align with the theme of the hackathon: **Sustainable Innovation in Tourism.**

The hackathon is **open-ended** - participants may propose **any idea, solution, or initiative** that promotes innovation within the tourism sector.

Projects may take the form of but are not limited to:

- **Technology-driven solutions** (apps, platforms, data systems, prototypes, etc.),
- **Marketing campaigns or communication strategies**
- **New tourism concepts, destinations, or experiences**
- **Policy initiatives** that enhance the visitor journey or community impact.

Projects should be **original** and **developed during the hackathon.** Use of existing ideas or open-source resources is welcome if properly credited.

2. Team Eligibility and Participation

Teams must consist of the **same members who registered** **prior to the event.** Substituting or adding new members after registration is **not permitted.**

Only registered participants are allowed in the hackathon workspace. **External advisors, faculty members, or guests** are not permitted to assist or be present during development or presentations.

All registered team members are expected to be **present for the full duration** of the hackathon and actively contribute to their project.

If a team member needs to step away temporarily (e.g., for health or emergency reasons), they **must inform the organizers** in advance.

Any violation of these participation rules may result in **disqualification** or removal from the event.

At the end of the hackathon, **10 shortlisted teams** will have the opportunity to present their project to the judges.

- Each team will be given **5 minutes** to present their idea or project, followed by **3 minutes for questions** from the judging panel.

- Teams must **submit their presentation materials** (e.g., slides, video, demo link, or visuals) **before the presentation period begins** as announced by the organizers.
- The **format of the presentation is entirely up to the team** - you may use slides, videos, mockups, live demos, campaign visuals, or any creative medium that best communicates your idea and impact.
- Judges will assess the presentation based on **clarity, creativity, relevance, and overall impact**, regardless of the chosen format.
- The goal is to effectively convey **what you built or conceptualized, why it matters, and how it contributes to innovation in tourism.**

3. Mentorship and Support

Throughout the hackathon, mentors from a **wide range of fields** will be available to support participants.

Mentors are **not assigned to specific teams.** Instead, teams are encouraged to **approach any mentor** whose expertise aligns with the challenge they are working on at that moment.

Participants are welcome to seek feedback on ideas, technical approaches, business models, design choices, or presentation strategies.

Please be respectful of mentors' time and other teams waiting for assistance.

4. Generative AI Usage Policy

Participants are **permitted to use generative AI tools** (e.g., ChatGPT, GitHub Copilot, DALL·E, Midjourney, Claude, etc.) during the hackathon.

Disclosure is mandatory. Before presenting your pitch, each team must submit a brief **AI Usage Disclosure Document** outlining:

- Which AI tools were used.
- What specific components were generated (e.g., code snippets, text, images, design concepts).
- How the generated outputs were integrated or modified.
- This document must be uploaded along with your presentation.

Failure to disclose AI usage may result in **deduction of points or disqualification** at the judges' discretion.

Judges will evaluate the team's originality, understanding, and technical contribution - not the AI tool's output itself.